

Exercise: Rules Workshop

Part 1 — Personal Rules (10 min)

Write 6-8 personal rules for your Cursor settings.

These apply globally — to everything you do in Cursor, on any project.

Open **Cursor Settings** → **Rules** → **User Rules** and add them there.

Good categories to consider:

Category	Example
Error handling	"Use exceptions for unexpected errors. Never return null to signal failure."
Dependencies	"Do not install new packages without asking me first."
Code structure	"Keep functions under 40 lines. Extract when longer."
AI behavior	"Before writing code, state your assumptions. Wait for my confirmation."
Never do	"Do not create or modify .env files. Do not delete files without confirmation."
Testing	"Every new function needs at least one test. Test the happy path and one failure case."

Quality check before saving: For each rule, ask — *"If Cursor violated this and I caught it, would I send it back?"* If yes, it's a real rule. If you'd let it slide, cut it.

Part 2 — Project Rules for the Capstone (15 min)

Use **Plan mode** in Cursor to draft project rules for the mCase Config Browser.

Use this prompt:

```
I'm going to build a web app that browses the mCase configuration API.
The app is for internal use by configuration managers.
I haven't chosen a tech stack yet – that's part of my architect process.

Draft a set of project rules (.cursor/rules/project-rules.mdc) for this project.
Focus on:
- Error handling philosophy (prefer exceptions over fallbacks)
- What Cursor should always stop and ask before doing
- What Cursor should never do without explicit instruction
- File structure expectations

Do NOT assume a tech stack. Write rules that apply regardless of framework.
Ask me any questions you need to write good rules.
```

Review the output. Edit until each rule is:

- An assertion, not a request
- Something you'd actually enforce
- Scoped appropriately

Save the result to `.cursor/rules/project-rules.mdc` with this frontmatter:

```
---  
alwaysApply: true  
---
```

Part 3 — Peer Review (5 min)

Swap your personal rules with a neighbor. Give 3 minutes to critique:

- Are these assertions or requests?
- Are any obviously redundant (would any decent developer do this anyway)?
- Is there a rule missing that would prevent a common Cursor mistake?

Share one piece of feedback each.